AMERICAN VOICES

1.2 Christopher Columbus 1451–1506

"By prevailing over all obstacles and distractions, one may unfailingly arrive at his chosen goal or destination." —Christopher Columbus



Hero or villain? The debate over Columbus's legacy has raged, particularly over the last several decades. Whether he's seen as the discoverer of the New World or the destroyer of native peoples, the fact is that Columbus's voyages opened up the world. Our global society wouldn't exist without him.

Of course, since Christopher Columbus's chosen goal was Asia, he didn't actually arrive at his destination. He got distracted by North America, which he confused with India. And Columbus didn't know that a group of Vikings led by Leif Eriksson got to North America more than 500 years before him. Still, in a very real sense, Columbus didn't fail at all. His discoveries and the impact they had were far greater than the route he set out to find.

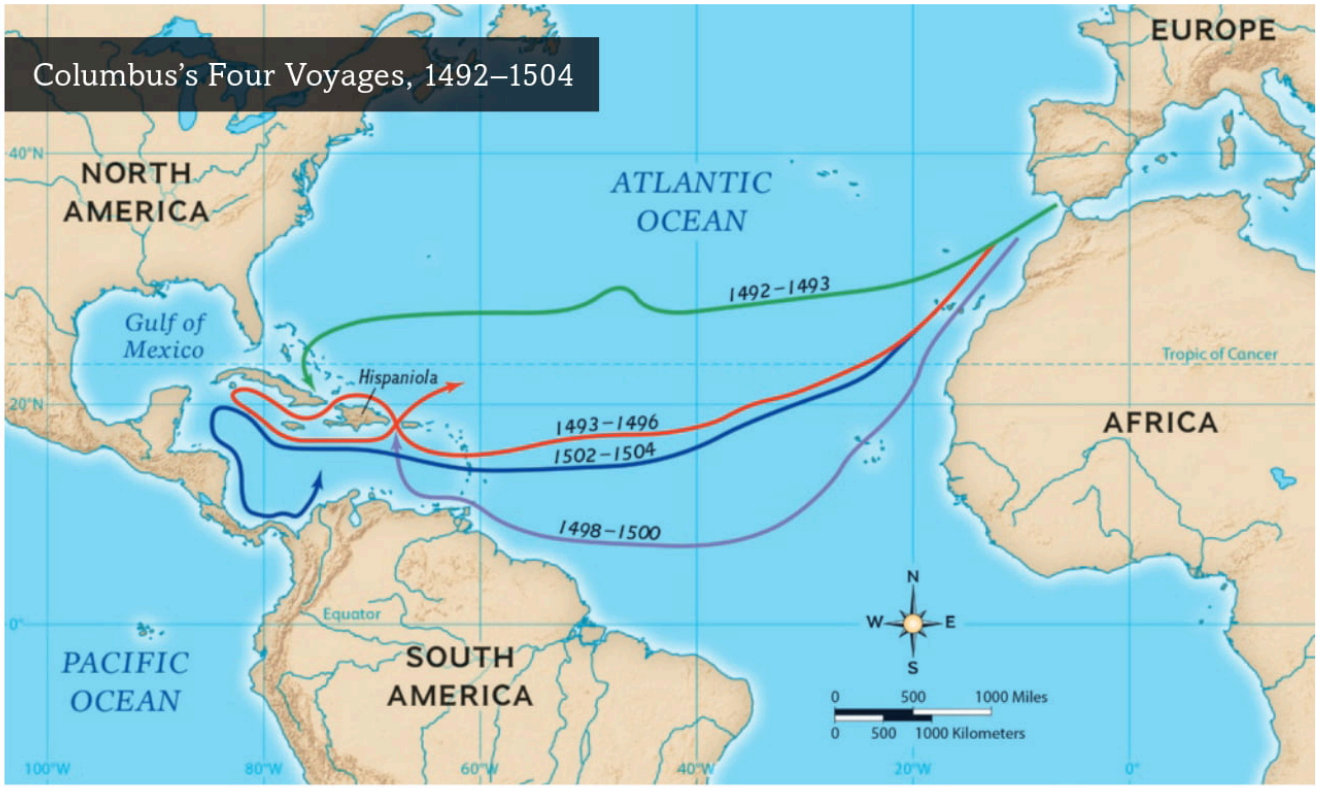
EXPLORATION OBSESSION

Like many boys born in the coastal city of Genoa, Italy, in the 1400s, young Christopher Columbus sought his fortune on the sea. He first set sail in 1465, when he was just a teenager. About 10 years later, he was on a ship bound for the Mediterranean when the vessel was sunk by pirates. Luckily, Columbus was able to cling to a bit of wreckage from the ship and swim to shore.

With perhaps even greater luck, he ended up in Lisbon, Portugal, where the exploration craze was at its height. There, Columbus studied navigation, cartography (mapmaking), and astronomy, and became obsessed with finding a westward route to Asia. He also read accounts of the riches of the East and decided he would try to bring these precious items back to Europe.

Columbus planned his journey to Asia based on the misinformation that most Europeans of the time accepted as fact—including an underestimation of Earth's circumference. Based on what he thought he knew, Columbus calculated the distance from Portugal to Japan and determined that the seagoing vessels of the day could handle it. Plan in hand, he looked for a sponsor to fund his journey. He finally found his backers in King Ferdinand and Queen Isabella of Spain.

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Portraits of Columbus

These three portraits of Columbus are very different because no one really knows what he looked like. But his contemporaries described him as a tall man with blond or red hair and beard and blue eyes.



VOYAGES TO THE "NEW WORLD"

On October 8, 1492, as Columbus neared the island he would call San Salvador, he declared "the air soft as that of Seville [a city in Spain] in April, and so fragrant that it was delicious to breathe it." It must have seemed a promising beginning, but his voyages did not turn out the way he hoped.

On the first voyage, he established a settlement on the island of Hispaniola. On the second voyage, he discovered the settlement had been destroyed. He left his two brothers in charge and then returned on his third voyage to find the colonists in revolt. The situation got so bad that a new governor was sent to the island, and Columbus was brought back to Spain in chains. Ferdinand and Isabella eventually pardoned him and even funded his fourth voyage. But he returned from this final trip empty-handed.

Columbus died a few years later, still believing he had found a route to Asia. No matter, though. While he hadn't discovered the riches he dreamed of, he had blazed a trail from Europe to what came to be known as the West Indies. He had opened up a "new world" to exploration and colonization and changed the course of history.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** How did Columbus plan to sail to Asia?
2. **ANALYZE CAUSE AND EFFECT** What happened as a result of Columbus's voyages?
3. **MAKE INFERENCES** What qualities do you think Columbus must have possessed to plan and carry out his voyages?

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